

1825-1900

THE TRANSPORT REVOLUTION

Advances in steam power, iron and steel production, and engineering fuelled a revolution in transport in the 19th century. Large-scale works such as the Erie Canal, linking New York City and the midwest, and the Suez Canal, joining the Mediterranean and Red seas, boosted development in the US and intercontinental trade respectively. While steamboats plied their trade along the US's great lakes and rivers, steam ships carried passengers around the world, furthering the aims of imperialism. However, the biggest impact on 19th-century mobility was made by the railways.

The pioneer of rail was British engineer George Stephenson, whose locomotive was the first to carry passengers on a public rail line, the Stockton and Darlington Railway, opened in 1825. Within decades, lines were crossing continents, revolutionizing the speed at which goods and people could be moved. These developments fuelled waves of immigration: thousands of indentured workers from Japan and China came to build America's railways; the Irish poor escaped famine on the transatlantic steamships; and many others sought their fortunes in India and South Africa.



KEY MOMENTS

1838 SS *Great Western* crosses the Atlantic

The first steamship purpose-built for crossing the Atlantic, Isambard Kingdom Brunel's SS *Great Western* (left) reached New York from England in 15½ days, beginning the first regular transatlantic steamship service.

1859 Construction of the Suez Canal begins

Overseen by French engineer Ferdinand de Lesseps, thousands of forced labourers began digging out the 193 km (120 mile) long channel (left) that would link Port Said on the Mediterranean Sea with Suez, on the Red Sea. The canal was completed in 1869, cutting the need to round the Cape of Good Hope.

1869 US Atlantic and Pacific coasts linked

Combining two railways – the Central Pacific (starting from San Francisco) and the Union Pacific (starting from Omaha, Nebraska) – the Transcontinental Railway (left) linked the US east and west coasts. It was an invaluable trade conduit that helped fuel exports across both the Pacific and Atlantic oceans.

